3.3 Digital relationship lifecycles

Considering the lifecycle of digital relationships helps ensure that authentication and authorization remain accurate, secure, and aligned with changes in both other systems and in the physical world. Without a well-managed lifecycle, your risk of unauthorized access, orphaned accounts, and policy misalignment increases.

Figure 3.3 shows the phases of the relationship lifecycle. Each phase changes depending on the type of relationship we're trying to create and its purpose.

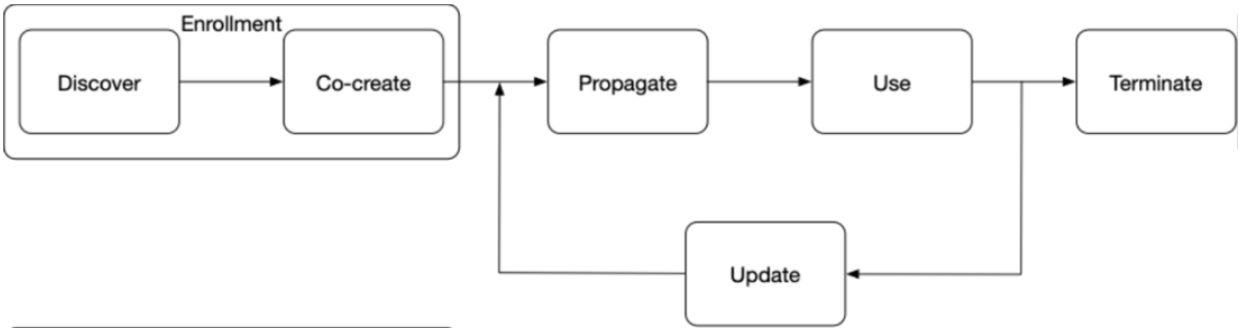


Figure 3.3 Phases in the digital relationship lifecycle. It begins with enrollment, comprising discovery and co-creation, and continues through propagation, use, and eventual termination. The update phase ensures that changes to the account or its attributes are integrated back into propagation, keeping the relationship accurate and aligned with current conditions.

3.3.1 Enrollment (discover and co-create)

Enrollment consists of two sub-phases: discovery and co-creating. For many relationships, the discovery phase is straightforward. For example, employees are told where to create employee accounts. For others, like a device joining a network, discovery might be governed by a protocol like Bluetooth.

I use the term *co-create* rather than just *create* to emphasize that this is a relationship and both sides will participate in a ceremony of sorts where information is exchanged. Co-creating a digital relationship happens when identifiers are chosen or assigned, credentials like passwords or other authentication factors are initialized, and attributes are exchanged. This process may include identity proofing, credential issuance, and linking the